

Architecture or Techno-Utopia

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Architecture or Techno-Utopia

FELICITY D. SCOTT

In August 1976, *l'Architecture d'aujourd'hui* published a dossier prepared by Brian Brace Taylor, entitled "New York in White and Gray." Tracing various lines of demarcation emerging around the battle of the "Grays" and the "Whites" (also known as "inclusivism" versus "exclusivism," or "neorealism" versus "neorationalism"),¹ this issue marked the first appearance of Manfredo Tafuri's article, "The Ashes of Jefferson," which appeared alongside Robert Stern's "Gray Architecture as Post-Modernism, or, Up and Down from Orthodoxy."² In "The American Night Time," chief editor Bernard Huet's introduction to this "not-the-bicentennial issue," the conjunction of New York's "urban crisis" and its concentration of the "most highly-refined architectural 'avant-garde'" was used to reflect on American cultural imperialism and to posit it as a "warning." Pointing to the "perfect (and illusory) correlation between a mode of modern architectural expression, functional and efficient, and the economic and technical development of the most advanced form of capitalism," Huet noted the long-standing fascination this correlation held for both French architects and their clients. As its counterpart in the 1970s, he posited the nostalgic contemplation by American architects of both the Parisian Beaux-Arts and the modernist avant-garde.

For Huet, American architecture was characterized by a "generalized architectural consumption" that collapsed distinctions between commercial modernism and the polemics of both the Grays and the Whites. Architectural production, he proposed, was caught between two consumer systems: "one is based upon the market value of construction, where architecture is reduced to the level of symbol; the other one, which is more recent, integrates architectural production into the art market and addresses itself to the artistic and speculative enjoyment of the collector or museum." If John Portman, Philip Johnson, and Kevin Roche would serve as examples of the former—of architecture "completely immersed in the system of production"—Peter Eisenman, John Hejduk, and Robert A. M. Stern would be situated together in the latter category, condemned, in Huet's analysis, to "asking themselves questions endlessly about a language emptied of all substance, through the production of paper architecture or unique, luxury objects." For Huet, perhaps editorializing Tafuri's text, which followed, both "uncritical submersion" within the system of production and "slavish submission" to a perverse private enjoyment would be insufficient "to get out of this impasse." Nor would placing "oneself outside the system of production" have any

Friedrich St. Florian.
Imaginary Space, 1968.



effect. Paying homage to Walter Benjamin's essay "The Author as Producer," he proposed, "The solution for us can only emerge by placing ourselves *within* these relationships so that we may transform them."³

Like Huet, Tafuri would also position the Grays and the Whites together in a single category. Despite the apparent polarization, their debate remained caught as dialectically opposed poles within a common project of recuperating architectural semantics. "The theme of 'resemanticization' is central" for both camps, Tafuri argued; "only the instruments employed to reach such an objective vary."⁴ For him, however, the question remained, To what was this common resemanticization opposed?

Stern answered this most succinctly, pointing to late modernism. He explained that "the 'White and Gray' debate is not (as has been suggested in the press) an encounter between polarities such as might have occurred in 1927 between advocates of the Beaux-Arts and apostles of International Style modernism." Rather, he went on, this negotiation of the 1970s took the form of an "ongoing dialog" that shared a common goal: "to chart out and clarify a direction which architecture can take now that the orthodox Modernist Movement has drawn to a close."⁵ For Stern, writing on behalf of both his own "Post-Modern" position and Peter Eisenman's "Post-Functionalism," it was "safe to say that the orthodox Modernist Movement is a closed issue, an historical fact." With reference to the pivotal importance of Arthur Drexler's 1975 exhibition, *The Architecture of the Ecole des Beaux-Arts*, Stern suggested that "Modern architecture might find a way out of the dilemma of the late Modern Movement by entering a period where symbolism and allusion would take their place alongside issues of formal composition, functional fit, and constructional logic."⁶ For Stern, the symbolism and allusion, sought after by the post-modern architecture of the Grays, was to be "a cue system that helps architects and users communicate better about their intentions."⁷ Indeed, architecture was to speak again, to "comment" on the present. "'Gray' buildings," Stern proposed, "have facades which tell stories."⁸

To this Tafuri would famously reply, "[N]othing remains but to gather around the hearth to listen to the fables of the new grannies."⁹ Like the conventional codes and normative aesthetics of "orthodox modernism," this talking architecture remained mired in myth and would prove as disturbing to the Italian historian. In another, contemporaneous context, Tafuri proclaimed the advent of semiology and structuralism in architecture.¹⁰ Yet with respect to the Gray and White debate, he was prompted to ask, "But what does the 'recovery of the semantic' mean? Why establish, today, such an objective? And of what, ultimately, must the architectural signs 'speak of again?'"¹¹

With respect to this "resemanticization," one could embark on many trajectories, but here I want simply to follow one, questioning how the resemanticization that was central to the staging of a Gray and White debate effectively foreclosed alternative

reevaluations of modernism. While debates on architectural meaning were ostensibly played out over the death throes of late modernism, with most modernist tropes figured as merely straw men,¹² the “modernist orthodoxy” cited by Stern was clearly not the main threat to either the White’s neo-avant-garde position or that of the “post-avant-garde” Grays. What their particular return to semantic codes foreclosed was not only the modernist shibboleths of “formal composition, functional fit, and constructional logic,” but also the investigations inaugurated by what Peter Cook would refer to as “experimental architecture.” This, in Cook’s terms, would open the discipline up to its complex articulation with contemporary technology; it was nothing less than “to *experiment out of architecture*.”¹³

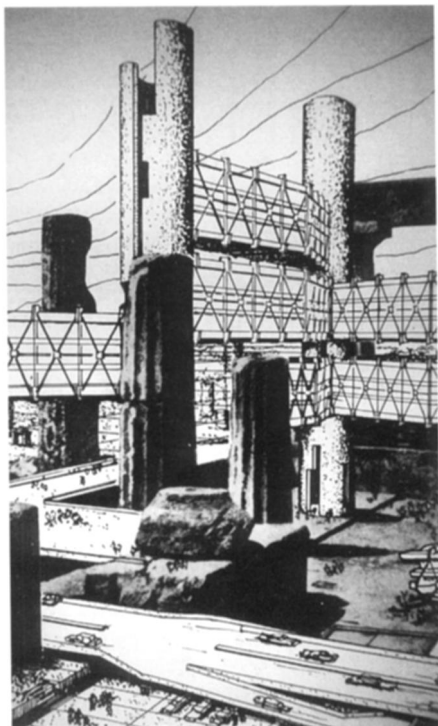


The suppression of experimental architecture through the terms of the Gray/White debate was noted at the time by Richard Pommer, a critic for *Artforum*. In an article entitled “The New Architectural Supremacists,” Pommer pointed to the emergence of the New York Five as a modernist counterpoint to “the architectural recognition granted in the ’60’s to commercial, consumer and science-fiction imagery.” Recounting the events of a symposium held at the Rhode Island School of Design in the Spring of 1976, Pommer noted, “Eisenman divided the members of the symposium into opposing camps, a false avant-garde of the ’60’s, and a true modernism of the ’70’s. He included himself in the latter.”¹⁴ Relegated to the former category were a number of experimental architects; along with Peter Cook, Eisenman included Michael Webb, Hans Hollein, Friedrich St. Florian, and, at least in part, Arata Isozaki.¹⁵

For Pommer, Eisenman’s modernism consisted primarily of the formalist analyses of Clement Greenberg mixed with that of Eisenman’s teacher, Colin Rowe. Earlier in the decade, in the introduction to *Five Architects*, Rowe had assimilated commercial modernism and the emergent experimental lineage (then still forging transformations in the functionalist paradigm). He described the former (in his terms “the camp of success”) as simply a less self-conscious version of the latter, the “true believers.” Such “true believers,” Rowe explained, which included any prospect of a postwar European avant-garde, were naively committed to the authenticity of the modern movement’s social and political agenda in the face of its actual failure. In attempting to revitalize the radical promise of modernism, they remained “obliged to detach [themselves] from success.” For Rowe, however, this was already a lost battle. After listing a “succession of fractional style phases”—among which he included Team 10¹⁶—he singled out Archigram, “in terms of which involutions,” he insisted, “any consideration of architecture in the Nineteen Seventies must be based.” Indeed, he continued, the two camps (the camp of success and the true believers) “have, by now, so much interpenetrated, so infected

one another, so much exchanged arguments and apologetic, appearances and motifs, that to discriminate either is becoming a major operation.”¹⁷

Rowe invoked this distorted condition to assert the historical necessity of architecture’s autonomy as demonstrated by the New York Five. According to Rowe, Le Corbusier’s question of “Architecture or revolution?” had already been answered in America in 1776: “In the United States the revolution was assumed to have already occurred,” and modern architecture had therefore been introduced as a “suitable veneer for the corporate activities of ‘enlightened’ capitalism.”¹⁸ Thus, while within the folklore of modernism European architecture was understood to have acted out the dialectic of enlightenment—



in which rationality was supposed to overcome myth, but which remained mired in a no less mythical positivism¹⁹—its American counterpart, the International Style, was founded from the start upon an unquestioning commercialism, a postrevolutionary politics.

The experimentalists, however, offered other answers to the question “Architecture or revolution?” that were distinct from the posited autonomy of the New York Five, and their engagements with science fiction and computerization were not always simply assimilable to commercial work (although this is of course possible and will be the suspicion of Tafuri as well). If Rowe regarded engagements with technology and capital as increasingly indistinct, it was perhaps because he did not yet have the theoretical tools with which to investigate their emergent, even indeterminate, modes of differentiation. We will

Left: Arata Isozaki.
Incubation, 1961.

Right: Hans Hollein.
Mobile Office, 1969.

come back to this point, for it is precisely on Rowe's "ashes of Jefferson" that Tafuri will build his own melancholy reflection on this end of revolutionary politics.

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When Tafuri wrote in "The Ashes of Jefferson" that there exists "a widespread trend concerned with experimenting with private languages," he was referring to the debate of the Grays and Whites. And when he subsequently recounted that "such manipulations of linguistic materials, whether we are dealing with Eisenman or Venturi, proclaim a real event: 'the war is over,'" it was undoubtedly to Rowe's apologia for the New York Five that his funereal remarks referred.²⁰ Yet while for Rowe the project of autonomy could operate unproblematically in the postrevolutionary space of America, Tafuri would find it an inadequate answer to the project of social transformation—inadequate, that is, as a response to Huet's proposition that the architect place him- or herself into the capitalist system in order to transform it. If Rowe had described the position of the European avant-garde as trapped within the machinations of the dialectic of enlightenment, Tafuri would similarly characterize the American neo-avant-garde's project of autonomy as a new mythology. He saw the disarticulation from both "the public" and "real centers of decision making" as "the exaltation of its own apartness."²¹ Likening, in this regard, the New York Five to Louis Kahn and Robert Venturi, Tafuri suggested that they "are only emblems of a 'condition' of intellectual work; or better, of the remnants of an intellectual work that believes itself capable of constituting itself as a closed space defended from intolerable encounters, a bridge spanning abysses that resound with noises whose mere echo seems deafening."²²

For Tafuri, American architecture's postrevolutionary condition meant that any attempt at avant-garde engagement would remain an unproductive act of submission to the sociotechnological, and hence capitalist, machine. Articulating a shift from the assumption of critical distance, from which the earlier avant-garde had operated, to the present condition of a totalizing, technical-commercial realm, Tafuri lamented,

The eye of the Constructivists and of the radical artists had assumed as its own duty remaining wide open behind the mechanical apparatus that governs the world, in the hope of being able to guide the movements of that apparatus. But faced with the discovery that on the set in which one thought oneself able to operate independent of external influences the true directional control was exerted by uncontrollable forces, "the archer with an eye and a half"—or, what amounts to the same, "the man with a movie camera"—is transformed into the man with half-closed eyes destined to end up in the limbo of somnambulism, wherein action remains action despite the semiunconscious state of the

actor. One can, however, maintain that such action without a subject is the only real action, the only real “repatriation,” the only action that reconciles one with the world.²³

Tafuri saw the contemporary subject as depleted of all agency. Now a sleeper, the subject was simply a moment of relay within the automatic actions propelled by capitalism’s uncontrollable forces. Tafuri’s formulation saw no mode of negotiating this space; his ironic “repatriation” was a forced assimilation in the face of the loss of ability for the artist to stand behind and guide the movements of the apparatus.

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If Rowe was one specter haunting “The Ashes of Jefferson,” the other was none other than Tafuri himself. Here, and at many other points in his article, Tafuri’s critique of the resemantization of American architecture replayed the arguments of an earlier, equally melancholic reflection on the capacity of architecture to maintain a social conscience within late capitalism. From the figure of the “Post-Modern tight-rope walker”—caught pirouetting within an abyss and thus unable to progress²⁴—to the accusation of a commercial imperative behind the return to allusion and semantics, to the architect’s capture within a system of control mediated by new technology, Tafuri’s recognition of the capacity of capitalism to overcome its contradictions had already been played out in “Design and Technological Utopia,” his contribution to the catalogue of Emilio Ambasz’s 1972 MoMA show, *Italy: The New Domestic Landscape*. As he explained with respect to *Architettura Radicale*, “All the intellectual anticonsumer utopias that seek to redress the ethical ‘distortions’ of the technological world by modifying the system of production or the channels of distribution only reveal the complete inadequacy of their theories, in the face of the actual structure of the capitalist economic cycle.”²⁵

For Tafuri, the most pernicious specter haunting “The Ashes of Jefferson” was the rise of architecture’s engagement with electronic technology and the behavioral sciences that signaled the emergence of an information economy and architecture’s engagement with it. Pointing specifically to the work of Archizoom, Superstudio, and Ugo La Pietra, among others, Tafuri argued that these Italian experimental architects had hoped to engage critically with the system of production and consumption. La Pietra’s “Domicile Cell,” for instance, operated precisely through situating itself within this system. As La Pietra (optimistically) explained the strategic intimacy of his domicile unit, “it becomes a center for gathering, processing and communicating information; a microstructure that can intervene in the information system by enlarging and multiplying exchanges among people, with everyone participating in the dynamics of communication.”²⁶ In much the same way as the Americans’ pursuit of autonomy, Tafuri believed that

Architettura Radicale had miserably failed and simply enhanced the automatic relays within the commercial system.

In distinction to his reading of the American turn to linguistics, however, here Tafuri perceived a link to other aspects of communications theory and media technologies that were driving this resemanticization:

Analytical studies of the theory of communication, meanwhile, avoided complete elucidation of the indissoluble links between technological aesthetics, the theory of symbols, and the capitalistic theory of development, to take on an ideology of compensation. . . . As an extensive information system directly involved with the world of advertising, design stands out as one type of activity in which indeterminate efforts at semantic restructuring could successfully regain for the discipline itself a “social,” “humane,” and even revolutionary role, to counteract “distortions in consumption.”²⁷

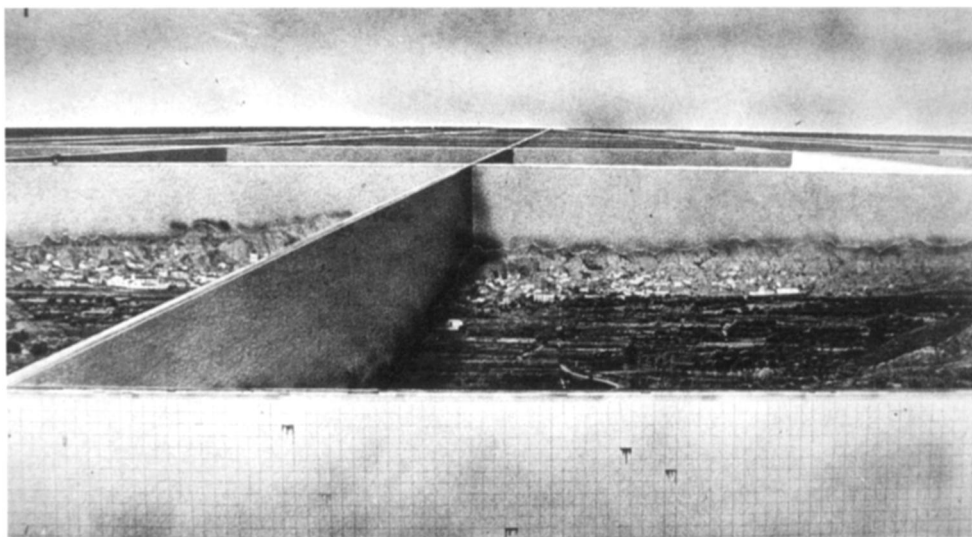
Evidently, for Tafuri, there remained a glimmer of hope that “semantic restructuring” could offer a mode of resistance. Yet he nonetheless proposed that the operative relations between communication and consumption, intimately tied to technological innovation and linguistic theory, had not been adequately theorized by architects in their engagement with these discourses (to which he referenced the work of Max Bense, Abraham Moles, and Edward Hall).²⁸ As he went on to explain, “[D]esigners didn’t let slip a convenient alibi for their intellectual work, responding to repeated invitations to ‘resemanticize’ the object and recover its myths.”²⁹ Thus, rather than achieving a strategic engagement with the modes of production and consumption—rather than a transformation of that commercial apparatus—Tafuri read this experimental engagement with technology as yet another form of mass deception. Meaning and allusion had returned as just another form of “styling.”

From the position of autonomy claimed by the American neo-avant-garde to the mode of engagement claimed by the Italian radicals, Tafuri saw any “action without a subject” leaving the architect simply a cog in the capitalist machine, although now a cybernetic machine rather than its earlier mechanical version. And in this sense we might liken his “Post-Modern tight-rope walker” to Sigfried Giedion’s earlier invocation of the “tightrope dancer who, by small adjustments, keeps a continuous balance between his being and empty space.”³⁰ For Giedion, this provided a dynamic model of “continuous change” conceptualized through physiological feedback mechanisms—the model of his “man in equipoise”—that was set in contrast to a historically outmoded “illusion of progress.” For Tafuri, however, it simply figured that horrifying vision of a loss of agency produced by an absolute capture within empty space.

In “Design and Technological Utopia,” Tafuri explained with irony the evacuation of agency suffered with the somnambulist’s assimilation into that system:³¹

The most important consequence of the discovery of the extent to which communications can be controlled lies precisely in the production of forms contained within the world of self-regulating systems. By leading experimentation in form and its uses back into the sphere of a process of collecting multiple information, design has found a suitable, independent field for development, closely intertwined with those forms of “repatriation” of subjectivity in that realm of artificiality par excellence, the city.³²

In distinction to this immersion within a totality offered by advances in communication technologies, Tafuri desired a form of engagement that would not operate through such an assimilation and that would refuse to be recuperated through a nostalgic return to mythology forged through allusion. For him this could not be achieved without a certain subjective agency; intervention into the system of production and consumption



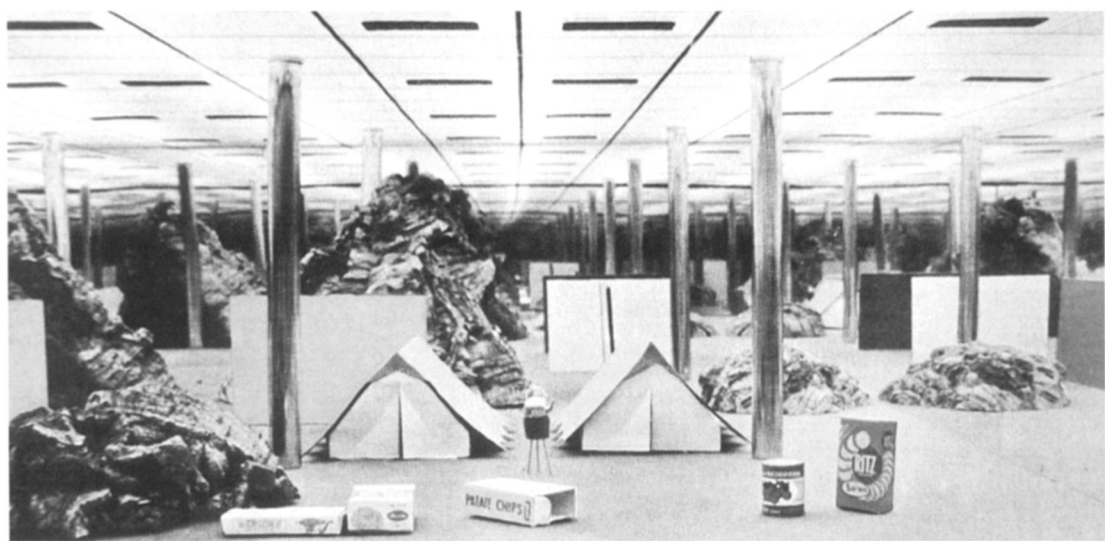
could not take place without opposition. From his critical position, as from that of Colin Rowe, the actual strategies formulated in the practices of experimental architecture remained entirely without a political efficacy.

These practices were not, however, without their own forms of contestatory, if somewhat ironic, negotiation.³³ For instance, we might point to the entirely dystopian fantasies of Superstudio’s “Twelve Cautionary Tales for Christmas,” or Archizoom’s “No-Stop City,” both of 1971. In the former we find a two-thousand ton ceiling panel descending on any rebellious inhabitants of a perfectly functioning intelligent architectural machine,³⁴ and in the latter a city modeled on an infinitely extended, continuous, and undifferentiated realm—like a parking garage or a supermarket—in which, as they note, “the complete penetrability and accessibility of the territory does away with the terminus city and permits the organization of a progressive network of organisms of control over the area.”³⁵

Above: Superstudio.
*First City: 2,000-ton
City, 1971.*

Opposite: Archizoom.
No-Stop City, 1971.

If this dialectic between Rowe and Tafuri seems an unlikely topic for close reflection at this moment, we might recall that Tafuri's "The Historical 'Project,'" republished as the introduction to *The Sphere and the Labyrinth* (which included "The Ashes of Jefferson"), was in dialogue with Gilles Deleuze and Felix Guattari, among others. "By no means do we intend to sing hymns to the irrational or interpret the ideological groups in the complex interactions as 'rhizomes' à la Deleuze and Guattari," Tafuri explained. "[H]istorical criticism must know how to balance on the razor's edge that separates detachment and participation."³⁶ With an oppositional paradigm figured as the only form of political action, Tafuri's project stands as a symptom of his refusal to engage other modes of political negotiation that emerged within the postwar condition of late capitalism.³⁷ For both Tafuri and Rowe, each committed to their



own notion of the avant-garde, the strategies forged by experimental architecture remained overshadowed by their lack of such a recognizable oppositional politics.

And it is precisely the articulation of another reading of Deleuze and Guattari with a recovery of the experimental architecture of the sixties and seventies that has recently become a defining topic in architectural practice at the turn of the millennium. The rise of interest in asignifying regimes and nonsemantic organizations is being forged through a new articulation with communications technology. Paradoxically, however, this articulation—which has the capacity to open up productive new lines of flight for a contestatory post-post-modern, even post-post-functionalist, practice—is at times deployed to operate the same depoliticization of experimental architecture that occurred at the hands of Tafuri and Rowe.³⁸ We are indeed in a “new historical space,” and one that has led to yet another “utopia of nostalgia.”³⁹ In its techno-euphoria, it is as though a

former foreclosure is still at work in this Deleuzian moment, in spite of Deleuze's own distinctly political agenda with regard to capitalism. While neither homogeneous in approach nor position, the contributions to the important *ANY* 23 issue "Diagram Work" and the response by *Daidalos*, "Diaggrammania," are at times symptomatic in this regard. The loss of aspects of this archive, both of Deleuze and Guattari and of experimental architecture, make this work available for a more immediate consumption.⁴⁰ Rather than forging a line of flight, it seems that we have come full circle. What Tafuri called Arthur Drexler's "lapidary-like" remarks in *Five Architects*, his suggestion that "architecture is the least likely instrument with which to accomplish the revolution," indeed makes a cogent, if ironic, inscription on the tombstone of the avant-garde in America.

Notes

1. In his editorial for *Oppositions* 5, Mario Gandelsonas outlined the two poles. Neorationalism, he explained, “depends on the idea of an architecture that is ‘autonomous,’ that is, on an architecture which, in the eyes of the most radical architects within this tendency, transcends history and culture; an architecture which is a force in itself and which does not communicate ideas other than its own.” Neorealism, in contrast, “is historical and cultural, it cares for the present, for the other aspects and practices of culture, such as pop art, advertising, cinema and industrial design to which it exposes architecture.” Mario Gandelsonas, “Neo-Functionalism,” *Oppositions* 5 (summer 1976): n.p.
2. The issue also included articles by Diana Agrest, Mario Gandelsonas, Rem Koolhaas, Kenneth Frampton, and others.
3. Bernard Huet, “La nuit américaine,” *l’Architecture d’aujourd’hui* 186 (August/September 1976): v.
4. Manfredo Tafuri, “The Ashes of Jefferson,” in *The Sphere and the Labyrinth: Avant-Gardes and Architecture from Piranesi to the 1970’s*, trans. Pelligrino d’Acierno and Robert Connolly (Cambridge: MIT Press, 1987), 298.
5. Robert A. M. Stern, “Gray Architecture as Post-Modernism, or, Up and Down from Orthodoxy,” translated back into English and reprinted in *Architecture Theory since 1968*, ed. K. Michael Hays (1976; reprint, New York: Columbia Books on Architecture, 1998), 243.
6. Stern, “Gray Architecture as Post-Modernism,” 243. The articulation of Drexler’s Beaux-Arts show with the discursive matrix set forth here is important and is more complex than can be traced here. It is the subject of a larger body of research by the author.
7. Stern, “Gray Architecture as Post-Modernism,” 244.
8. As Stern explained, “Scully has begun to influence not only architects but also historians like Neil Levine who, in his account of the Beaux-Arts, assigns great importance to questions of communication and in particular to that of an *architecture parlante*.” Stern, “Gray Architecture as Post-Modernism,” 245.
9. Tafuri, “The Ashes of Jefferson,” 298.
10. Manfredo Tafuri, *Theories and Histories of Architecture*, trans. Giorgio Verrecchia (New York: Harper and Row, 1980), 5.
11. Tafuri, “The Ashes of Jefferson,” 298.
12. A situation against which significant historical work is now being undertaken.
13. See Peter Cook, *Experimental Architecture* (New York: Universe Books, 1970), 13. Stern was, of course, correct to point out that the polemics of an “orthodox Modernist Movement” had become a historical fact by the mid-1970s, and Tafuri too would raise important questions by concentrating on the problematics entailed by such a return to “symbolism and illusion.” What I want to trace here, however, are the dynamics of this foreclosure. Beyond the historical importance it had to the direction taken by architectural discourse in the 1970s, and beyond the capacity of these terms to haunt that discourse, these terms have recently returned to challenge a semantic paradigm and to realign debates within contemporary practice. In excavating those terms, we might offer a preliminary archaeology of the present.
14. Richard Pommer, “The New Architectural Supremacists,” *Artforum* 15 (October 1976): 38. With respect to this opposition Pommer remarked, “It was a performance which few American architects have attempted since Philip Johnson read Art Deco out of the Museum of Modern Art in the 1930’s.” In fact, many commented on the power of this publicity mechanism to capture so skillfully the attention of the architectural profession and its vehicles of publication. Tafuri, for instance, posited that “forming a group is required in the professional jungle of America. It may have been nothing more than an instrument of self-promotion and of identification, a sort of makeshift life raft.” Tafuri, “The Ashes of Jefferson,” 297. Tafuri also mentioned the staging of “Five on Five,” which had been organized by Stern for an issue of *Architectural*

Forum (May 1973). Engaging that same mechanism of publicity, this polemical intervention into an “ongoing dialog” included “Stompin’ at the Savoye,” by Stern; along with “Machines in the Garden,” by Jacquelin Robertson; “In a Similar State of Undress,” by Charles Moore; “The Lurking American Legacy,” by Allan Greenberg; and “The Discrete Charm of the Bourgeoisie,” by Romaldo Giurgola. In the postscript added to the 1975 reprint of *Five Architects*, Philip Johnson also pointed to the cogency of the strategy: “There seems little sense in assembling these five architects in one book,” he began. “They no doubt felt they would collectively receive more exposure as five than as five ones. They were right. As five, they have been attacked and defended, praised and vilified.” *Five Architects: Eisenman, Graves, Gwathmy, Hejduk, Meier* (New York: Museum of Modern Art, Oxford University Press, 1975), 138.

15. Isozaki was supposedly able to position himself with a foot in each camp.

16. These included “the cult of townscape and the new empiricism, Miesian neoclassicism, neo-Liberty, the New Brutalism, Team X, [and] the Futurist Revival.”

17. Colin Rowe, “Introduction,” in *Five Architects: Eisenman, Graves, Gwathmy, Hejduk, Meier* (New York: Museum of Modern Art, Oxford University Press, 1975), 3. Peter Eisenman would also demonstrate his indebtedness to Rowe’s thinking on this topic on another occasion. In his editorial to *Oppositions* 6 (fall 1976), “Post-Functionalism,” he positioned Reyner Banham, Cedric Price, and Archigram as architects who “have understood design as the product of some oversimplified form-follows-function formula.” Indeed, for Eisenman, their “idealization of technology” continued a functionalist predicament in which the positivist project was affiliated with an outdated ethical and idealist perspective. Like Rowe, such work was thus to be collapsed into that of a mainstream modern architecture.

18. Rowe, “Introduction,” in *Five Architects*, 4.

19. In Rowe’s words, “Enlightenment won by bitter struggle was to speak to enlightenment which was innate. As simply a scientific determination of empirical data modern architecture was to be understood by *the natural man*; and hence that [*sic*] the modern building, believed to be purged of mythical content, became conceivable as the inevitable shelter for a mythical being in whose aboriginal psychology myth could occupy no place.” Rowe, “Introduction,” in *Five Architects*, 6.

20. Tafuri, “The Ashes of Jefferson,” 301.

21. Tafuri, “The Ashes of Jefferson,” 292.

22. Tafuri, “The Ashes of Jefferson,” 297. In this it appears that Tafuri agreed with Stern, who, we might recall, had positioned the Gray/White debate as distinct from the encounter produced in the earlier part of the century through the battle of the Beaux-Arts and the International Style. This closed space of postwar American discourse offered not an outside against which one could be opposed but, for Tafuri, a frightening abyss.

23. Tafuri, “The Ashes of Jefferson,” 294–95.

24. Tafuri, “The Ashes of Jefferson,” 301. As he explained, “Pirouetting on only one foot, the Post Modern tight-rope walkers endeavor to play their game with a history whose meaning and limits they skillfully keep hidden from themselves.”

25. Manfredo Tafuri, “Design and Technological Utopia,” in *Italy: The New Domestic Landscape: Achievements and Problems of Italian Design*, ed. Emilio Ambasz (New York: Museum of Modern Art, 1972), 388–404.

26. Ugo La Pietra, “The Domicile Cell: A Microstructure within the Information and Communication Systems,” in *Italy: The New Domestic Landscape: Achievements and Problems of Italian Design*, ed. Emilio Ambasz (New York: Museum of Modern Art, 1972), 228.

27. Tafuri, “Design and Technological Utopia,” 393–94.

28. As curator of the exhibition, Emilio Ambasz set out the specific and general considerations for the production of “microenvironments” by a series

of invited participants and, in addition, suggested primary reading for the designers. His suggestions included Harold M. Proshansky, William H. Ittelson, and Leanne G. Rivlin, eds., *Environmental Psychology: Man and His Physical Setting* (New York: Holt, Rinehart and Winston, 1970). This included articles by Edward T. Hall, "The Anthropology of Space: An Organizing Model," and others. The volume of texts accompanying the Design Program also included Aldo Van Eyck's passage from CIAM 59 in Otterloo. His terms explicitly call for a resemanticization of the domestic realm through the critical tools provided by psychological, sociological, and anthropological discourses.

29. Tafuri, "Design and Technological Utopia," 394. As though ratifying Ambasz's formulation, this was most visible in Superstudio's mythologically saturated images of a "distended" world and a nomadic, "tribal" life (presented in the section on "counterdesign"), as well as in the iconic design objects of Archizoom, Gruppo Strum, and Superstudio.

30. Sigfried Giedion, *Mechanization Takes Command: A Contribution to Anonymous History* (New York: W. W. Norton, 1948), 720.

31. It was, moreover, that same sleeper, as we have seen, who reappeared in "The Ashes of Jefferson."

32. Tafuri, "Design and Technological Utopia," 397.

33. If, for instance, the work of Team 10, Cedric Price, Archigram, Yona Friedman, and the Metabolists emerged through a certain techno-euphoria, and if experimental architects were initially fascinated by the liberatory possibilities offered by new communication and construction technologies, this would soon give way to a more complex, and more dystopian, but never simply techno-phobic, engagement. Although many architects experimented with open-ended, intelligent, and "flexible" structures, they quickly came to understand the other side of this feedback equation: the dispersed forms of control to which their strategies gave rise. With respect to the Pompidou Center in Paris, designed by Renzo Piano and Richard Rogers (1971–75), Alan Colquhoun would note, for instance, that the utopia of flexibility and an indeterminate program very quickly became "the occasion for the invention of a new type of bureaucrat—the 'programmer.'" Alan Colquhoun, "Plateau Beaubourg" (1977), in *Essays in Architectural Criticism: Modern Architecture and Historical Change* (Cambridge: MIT Press, 1981), 117. Concluding his memorial to *Megastructure*, Reyner Banham would also point to such a relation. "Note how once again, Philip Johnson had blown the gaff by saying that there would be Megastructure when *management* was ready," he explained. *Megastructure*, Banham continued, "was, obviously, close kin to Big Management; those to whom conglomerates and multi-nationals were unacceptable would find Megastructure unacceptable too." Reyner Banham, *Megastructure: Urban Futures of the Recent Past* (London: Thames and Hudson, 1976), 209.

34. Superstudio, "Twelve Cautionary Tales for Christmas," *Architectural Design* 42 (December 1971): 737–42.

35. Archizoom, "No-Stop City," *Domus* 496 (March 1971): 53.

36. Manfredo Tafuri, "Introduction: The Historical 'Project,'" in *The Sphere and the Labyrinth: Avant-Gardes and Architecture from Piranesi to the 1970's*, 11 and fn. 23.

37. It should be noted that we are not following Tafuri to his conclusions—a sort of paralysis in the face of "the actual structure of the economic cycle," a withdrawal into silence—but the problematics of his argument bring us back to the question of a politics of engagement and thus to the conjunction of "resemanticization" and its relation to communication technology. Theorizing such forms of negotiation was, of course, precisely Deleuze and Guattari's project. In a discussion with Antonio Negri, Deleuze pointed to the political vocation of his work with Guattari: "You see, we think any political philosophy must turn on the analysis of capitalism and the ways it has

developed,” he explained. “What we find most interesting in Marx is his analysis of capitalism as an immanent system that’s constantly overcoming its own limitations, and then coming up against them once more in a broader form, because its fundamental limit is Capital itself.” And for Deleuze, this reading of capitalism did not lead only to assimilation. As he explained with respect to prospects for resistance, “Creating has always been something different from communication. The key thing may be to create vacuoles of noncommunication, circuit breakers, so we can elude control.” See Gilles Deleuze and Toni Negri, “Control and Becoming,” in *Negotiations: 1972–1990*, trans. Martin Joughin (New York: Columbia University Press, 1995), 169–76.

38. And through the peculiar dynamics of architectural discourse, the rise of interest in asignifying regimes and nonsemantic organizations, articulated for instance through the Deleuzian concepts of the abstract machine and the diagram, is being staged as a necessary refusal of other critiques of signification—now cast as a regressive interest in representation per se. Others problematically collapse the theoretical paradigms, assimilating the notion of the diagram with that abstraction of the architect’s drawn diagram.

39. Tafuri, “Introduction: The Historical ‘Project,’” 17.

40. Reviewing Peter Eisenman’s book, *Diagram Diaries*, the editor of *Daidalos*, Gerrit Confurius, writes, “It’s been a few years since we’ve seen the term ‘diagram’; for two decades it was as good as non-existent. Now that it’s here again it can no longer be ignored, and we wonder how we got along without it. For a long time, few remembered how virulent it once was, in the 1960’s. Names like Christopher Alexander or D’Arcy Thompson were forgotten, and even the Smithsons or Cedric Price were hardly known. The actual outbreak of diagram fever was preceded by a certain period of incubation; smoldering below the threshold of public discourse, it was a sort of secret knowledge, like the honorary insignia of a lodge. Access to this cutting edge, to this avant-garde (OMA, Tschumi, Eisenman, and others) was impeded by the threat of having to read Deleuze, Guattari, and Foucault.” Gerrit Confurius, “The Architecture of Architecture: Peter Eisenman’s ‘Diagram Diaries,’” *Daidalos* 74 (October 2000): 86.